attempt to overhaul Bihar's voter lists in just 90 days, ostensibly to remove deceased voters, duplicates and those who had permanently migrated. The questioning of its legality, at least initially, pertained mainly to its sudden rollout at the last minute.

BIHAR'S VANISHING ROLLS

But, on August 1, when Bihar's draft rolls were published, the doubts had spread to other aspects. For, 6.56 million names had vanished, a massive 8.3 per cent reduction that shrank the state's electorate from 78.9 million to 72.4 million voters. Of these deletions, 2.23 million are classified as deceased, 3.63 million as permanently migrated or untraceable, and 700,000 as duplicates.

The Opposition sees a deeper design at work. Throughout the monsoon session, the INDIA bloc staged daily protests in Parliament, calling the SIR a political purge meant to 'fix' the upcoming assembly election. Opposition leaders and activists petitioned the Supreme Court, arguing that the exercise exceeded the ECI's constitutional mandate by demanding citizenship documents that could disenfranchise millions. They cited Section 22 of the Representation of the People Act, 1950, which requires electoral officers to give anyone facing deletion "a reasonable opportunity of being heard". How, they asked, could 6.5 million people be granted meaningful hearings in just weeks? By forcing citizens to prove their eligibility, they argued, the ECI had shifted the burden of proof onto the people, turning voting from a right into a privilege that had to be constantly earned.

Their criticism especially focused on the ECI's list of 11 acceptable documents, which excluded Aadhaar cards, voter ID cards and ration cards, the forms of identification most common among Bihar's poor. Instead, it demanded passports, birth certificates or pre-1987 government job IDs, effectively placing the franchise beyond reach for millions. Political analyst-turned-politician Yogendra Yadav, drawing on government data and field surveys, estimated that only 45-50 per cent of Bihar's 18-to-40-year-olds possessed one of the 11 documents demanded by the ECI. If enforced strictly, he warned, this "arbitrary decision" could strip at least 24 million of the state's 72.4 million registered voters of their franchise, making it "the largest disenfranchisement in the history of any electoral democracy". The SC, however, disagreed, rejecting the claim that most residents lacked the necessary papers. During the August 12 hearings, Justice Surya Kant also backed the ECI's position on Aadhaar, ruling it could not be treated as conclusive proof of citizenship. On August 13, the SC observed that the allowance of any of 11 documents for the Bihar SIR makes the exercise more "voter-friendly" than a regular summary revision, which accepts only seven.

Following the ECI's disclosure that 6.5 million names had been deleted, the Association for Democratic Reforms petitioned for the release of both the names and the specific reasons for each exclusion. The commission initially refused, arguing it had no legal obligation to publish separate deletion lists or provide individual explanations. However, it reversed the stance after the SC ordered it to publish district-wise lists of all omitted voters with reasons for deletion. The ECI will now release booth-wise lists, to be displayed at district election offices, on social media and through

Several BJP leaders claimed Rahul's exposé inadvertently aided the ECI, arguing his criticism of faulty rolls tacitly endorsed its SIR in Bihar

A CASE OF TRUST DEFICIT

Opposition parties have repeatedly questioned the Election Commission's impartiality. Many observers argue that, instead of hiding behind procedural rules, it must act to strengthen public trust in the institution



THE CHARGE Rahul alleges that fake and duplicate voters helped the BJP swing the Mahadevapura assembly segment in the Bangalore Central LS seat during the 2024 general election

ECI'S RESPONSE: He should file a formal, sworn complaint under Rule 20(3)(b) of the Registration of Electors Rules, 1960

TRUST SAFEGUARD: Experts say the ECI should have launched a probe and published the findings

THE CHARGE Rahul says the ECI's refusal to provide machine-readable electoral rolls of the past 10-15 years convinced him of its collusion with the BJP

ECI'S RESPONSE: Political parties already had physical copies

TRUST SAFEGUARD: Electoral rolls contain sensitive data; publishing them digitally could expose them to hacking, say experts